

STRESS

Common sense tells us that yoga helps to manage stress by promoting relaxation and holistic well-being. But understanding the science behind the calming power of yoga can empower us to take a more proactive approach to a less stressed life, which enables us to achieve more positive health outcomes.

Q HOW DOES STRESS IMPACT MY HEALTH? AND HOW DOES YOGA HELP?

We tend to think of all stress as bad, but healthy levels of positive stress—eustress—can help us perform at our best. However, too much negative stress is associated with mental health imbalances and chronic pain, along with many of the industrial world's major killers, including heart disease, stroke, and cancer. It's important to recognize that stress doesn't necessarily cause these diseases. Research suggests that the greatest predictor of whether or not you will suffer from these diseases is not how

much stress you experience, but how you deal with and think about stress. Those who have more negative emotions amid stress are more likely to experience negative health outcomes. Yoga is an effective tool for managing stress because it helps us regulate our emotional response to stressors by teaching us to become the observer of our thoughts and feelings, and through improving our mind-body connection (see right). As a result, yoga can lead to more positive health outcomes.

